A SPIN & ROLL CAMPAIGN

The Hollow Heir

Dungeon Master's Guide

Written by Zibby

Seven days at Hogwarts to stop a painted wizard.

Version 3.0. Year 1 with the living castle. Matches the complete app, October 2026.
Keep this book beside the GM screen. Update it whenever the app changes.

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to use this book

Everything you need to run The Hollow Heir, in the order you will need it.

This book follows the night from the first owl to the House Cup. Read it once before the first session, then keep it open beside the GM screen. You never have to read everything out: the boxes tell you what is for the players and what is just for you.

The four kinds of box

READ ALOUD

Parchment boxes are read aloud. Read them as written, or in your own words once you know them. They set the scene.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

Red boxes mean stop talking. Ask the question, then let the players answer and argue. Silence is fine. Do not rescue them too early.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Teal boxes tell you exactly what to press in the app, and when.

TIP

Gold boxes are optional advice. Use them if the moment needs a push.

Three rules for the table

- **The TV is the table.** The players look at the TV, decide together and tell you what they do. You do it for them on the GM screen. Phones are for their own sheet, dice, bag and classes.
- **Say "yes, and…"** If an idea is clever and fits the world, let it work, maybe with a roll. A good idea deserves house points.
- **The clock is the villain.** Every block that passes brings the ritual closer. When the players dither, remind them what time it is.

Words you will see

Word	Meaning
Block	One part of a day: Morning class, Lunch, Afternoon class, Free time, Curfew.
Check	A d20 roll plus a stat bonus against a difficulty (DC). Meet or beat it to succeed.
Defence	How hard a character is to hit. Enemies must roll this or higher.
Beat	A story moment that happens at a set time, whatever the players are doing.
Token	Anything on the map: students, staff, monsters, chests, items, hazards.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Setting up the night

Twenty minutes before anyone arrives.

The checklist

- Open the site on your laptop and sign in. From the DM dashboard, press **Create game** on The Hollow Heir.
- Press **Open GM screen** (your display) and **Open TV screen** (drag that window to the TV and make it full screen).
- The TV shows a four-letter join code. Players sign in on their phones and type it in. Their names pop up on the TV.
- **Click the TV window once** (the gold "Click to enable sound" button). Browsers block sound until someone clicks.
- Press **Start game** when everyone is in. The opening cutscene starts on the TV and every phone locks.
- Keep the GM screen open all night. It is the engine that carries out trades, purchases, attacks and chests.
- Physical props: the six wands (holly, yew, vine, ash, hawthorn, oak), the Hogwarts letters, snacks. Bertie Bott's Beans if you can find them.
- Open the **Media** tab and check the file checklist. Play the intro and the jump scare once to be sure they are the right files. Missing files fall back to the built-in versions, so it is never a disaster.

> **ON THE GM SCREEN**
>
> Header controls: **music** picker and volume, **Main event** (locks every phone), **Points**, the shop switch and the join code. The GM screen has tabs: **Table** (map, moving people, placing things, fights), **Day & class**, **Quests**, **Puzzles**, **TV shows**, **Players**, **Wheels**.

Pacing: how long it really is

Played in full, The Hollow Heir runs **14 to 18 hours**. The prologue and Sorting take about two and a half hours on their own (Ollivanders and the Sorting Hat are about five minutes per player each), and each in-game day takes one and a half to two hours. Plan for three sessions.

Session	Covers	Ends on	Time
One	Opening cutscene, letters, Gringotts, Diagon Alley, Ollivanders, the Express, Sorting, Feast, Days 1 and 2	The Sinclair prefect drained (Day 2, Curfew)	5 hrs
Two	Days 3, 4 and 5: the library, the missing page, Flying, Alohomora, the Room of Requirement	Grimsby caught over a victim (Day 5, Curfew)	5 hrs
Three	Hogsmeade (Day 6), Day 7, the Trials, the Undercroft, the finale	Awards, the House Cup, saving characters	5 hrs

Every session ends on a cliffhanger beat, and each one starts with a recap: ask the players to tell you the story so far.

If you only have two sessions

Cut, don't rush. In this order:

- **Teach some classes without a minigame** (Day & class tab). Keep the minigames for Charms, Defence and Flying; they are the most fun.
- **Shorten the prologue:** two Ollivanders questions per player instead of five (just read the first two, then press Give this wand), and shop for ten minutes, not twenty.
- **Merge free blocks:** on Days 3 and 4, treat Lunch and Free time as one block. Press Advance time twice.
- **Drop side quests** nobody has picked up. Keep Wake the Sleepers and The Other Half; they feed the main story.
- **Skip the Trials** and use the Marlowe serpent key into the Undercroft.

Never cut the beats. They are the story.

> **TIP**
>
> Watch the clock, not the plan. If the table is having the time of its life in Hogsmeade, let it run and cut something quieter later.

PART 1

The Prologue

From the opening credits to the Sorting Hat.

1.0 The opening cutscene

When you press **Start game**, the TV plays the opening. Every phone shows **Main Event: pay attention to the screen** and cannot be tapped. Dim the lights.

- **Your intro video**, if you made one (*public/video/intro.mp4*). When it ends, the book appears by itself.
- Otherwise the built-in opening: **the studio ident** (about 8 seconds: clouds part around a golden GM crest, then your name and "presents") and **the title** (about 8 seconds: *Harry Potter and the Hollow Heir* in gold, with rising embers).
- **The storybook:** a red leather book appears, closed. You turn the pages from the GM screen.

ON THE GM SCREEN

A **Opening cutscene** panel sits at the top of the GM screen. Press **Open the book**, then **Next page** after each page. The panel shows the words for each page so you can read them aloud (or they play by themselves if you recorded them). After page 6, press **Turn to "Choose your family"**.

READ ALOUD

Page 1. *Three hundred years ago, a painter named Corvin Vale made portraits so lifelike that people swore his subjects breathed.*

Page 2. *He feared one thing above all others: growing old. So he began his greatest work, a portrait of himself that would never age, never fade, and never end.*

Page 3. *To finish it, he needed the light of the young. Students began to be found at dawn, grey and silent, as if someone had painted them in ash.*

Page 4. *A family called Blackwood stopped him. They sealed Vale inside his own unfinished canvas, and hid it where no one would ever think to look.*

Page 5. *For three centuries, the painting slept. Until this summer, when someone found it, wrapped it in grey cloth, and put it on a train to Hogwarts.*

Page 6. *Six families are about to receive a letter. Six children are about to begin their first year. None of them know that the painting is waiting for them.*

TIP

Read slowly. Pause after each page before turning. The page turn has its own sound; let it land. If you made your own intro video, wait for it to finish before pressing Open the book.

On the family page, the six families appear in the book and the phones unlock. As each player claims a family, the book stamps their first name onto that family's card.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

"Look at your phones. You were born into one of six families. Read them, argue about them, and choose. Then give yourself a first name." Give them five minutes.

ON THE GM SCREEN

When everyone has chosen, press **Close the book and begin**. The book closes, the phones stay locked for a moment, then the game begins. Go straight to the family vignettes below.

1.1 Letters arrive

ON THE GM SCREEN

The clock starts at **Prologue: Letters arrive**. On the Table tab, choose **Home** and press **Just show on TV**.

READ ALOUD

Somewhere in Britain, on an ordinary morning at the end of summer, an owl lands where no owl should be.

It is carrying a heavy envelope of yellowish parchment, addressed in emerald-green ink. The seal is a coat of arms: a lion, an eagle, a badger and a snake, around a large letter H.

You are eleven years old. In about a minute, everything you thought you knew about your life is going to change.

If you skipped the cutscene, players choose their families now on their phones. Otherwise they already have.

Go round the table. Read the family's vignette, then hand that player their physical letter.

Blackwood

READ ALOUD

The letter arrives on a silver tray, carried by a butler-elf who bows so low his nose touches the carpet. Above the fireplace, three generations of painted Blackwoods lean out of their frames to read over your shoulder. "About time," sniffs your great-great-grandmother. "We were starting to think you were a Squib."

Sinclair

READ ALOUD

Your parents are away again, hunting someone dangerous for the Ministry. The owl finds you alone at the kitchen table. Tucked inside your letter is a second note in your sister's handwriting: "See you at school. Keep your eyes open this year. Something feels wrong. Don't tell Mum."

Fenwick

READ ALOUD

The owl crashes straight through the window of Fenwick's Fizzing Follies and lands in a crate of Dungbombs. When you finally open the letter, it explodes into green confetti. Your family cheers. Later, alone, you open the drawer you are not supposed to open, and unfold the half of a faded old map that lives there.

Thornbury

READ ALOUD

The owl lands on the gate of the hippogriff paddock, and the whole herd bows to it. You read the letter sitting on the fence beside an empty stall. The nameplate on the stall still says Bramble. Your family stopped talking about her months ago. You never stopped listening for her.

Quill

READ ALOUD

The first letter comes through the letterbox. Your dad throws it away. The next morning there are twelve. By the weekend there are hundreds, and a tall witch in a pointed hat is standing on your doorstep politely asking your parents, both dentists, if she might come in. "You're a witch," she tells you. "Or a wizard. Either way, you're late."

Marlowe

READ ALOUD

The owl finds you in a cold, dusty manor where half the rooms are shut and the portraits have all been turned to face the wall. Nobody has written to a Marlowe in years. Your grandfather reads the letter twice, then presses an old iron key into your hand. It is carved like a serpent. "Keep it hidden," he says. "Some doors remember our name."

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

For each player: "Tell us one thing about you that nobody at Hogwarts knows yet." Their answers are gold for later. Write them down.

ON THE GM SCREEN

If someone says they already know a spell, teach it on the **Spells** tab: pick the student, tap **Teach**, and leave **Announce on the TV** off so it stays their secret. Not in the list? Use **Make a custom spell** at the bottom.

TIP

Keep backstory spells small: Reparo, Wingardium Leviosa, Episkey, Aguamenti. A first-year who already knows Bombarda breaks the week. If they ask for something big, say yes with a cost: it works once, or it drains them.

TIP

Each player can read their **family secret** on their own phone (Sheet tab). Remind them it is secret. They can share it whenever they like, or never.

1.2 Gringotts

ON THE GM SCREEN

Day & class tab: **Advance time** to **Gringotts and Diagon Alley**. Table tab: choose **Gringotts**, tick everyone, **Move them here**.

READ ALOUD

Diagon Alley swallows you whole: cauldrons stacked outside shops, owls hooting in cages, a witch selling eyeballs by the jar. At the top of the street stands a snowy-white building with bronze doors. Gringotts Wizarding Bank. A goblin in scarlet and gold looks you up and down as if pricing you. "Vault keys," he says. "Or account names. Quickly."

Do the vaults one at a time. It is a great moment to show who is rich and who is not.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Players tab: on each card press **Open the [family] vault**. The TV announces the amount.

Family	Vault	Say this as the door opens
Blackwood	500 Galleons	"Mountains of gold. The goblin almost smiles."
Sinclair	300 Galleons	"Neat stacks of gold, and a note from your parents: Spend wisely."
Fenwick	220 Galleons	"Gold, a few joke-shop IOUs, and something that fizzes."
Thornbury	150 Galleons	"A modest pile of gold, and a hippogriff feather someone left for luck."
Quill	60 Galleons	"The Hogwarts fund for Muggle-born students. Enough, if you are careful."
Marlowe	25 Galleons	"A handful of coins. The goblin glances at the serpent key in your pocket, and says nothing."

1.3 Diagon Alley

ON THE GM SCREEN

Header: press **Open shops**. Table tab: move everyone to **Diagon Alley**.

READ ALOUD

You have a list from Hogwarts and a pocket full of gold that looks like a pirate's treasure. Every shop window wants you. Madam Malkin's robes. The Magical Menagerie, where something in the back is purring very loudly. Flourish and Blotts, stacked to the ceiling with books. And at the far end, a narrow, dusty shop with a single wand on a faded cushion in the window.

On their phones, the **Shop** tab now has a school list that ticks itself off. Every student needs robes, a familiar, a cauldron and a book set. The wand comes from Ollivanders, which you run.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

"You have about fifteen minutes before Ollivanders closes. What do you buy? Who is helping who?" The cheapest full school list costs 20 Galleons, so the Marlowe can only just afford it. Watch whether anyone shares.

TIP

Generosity deserves a reward. If a rich student pays for someone else, give the giver **+5 house points** once they are sorted, or remember it for the feast.

The rival

READ ALOUD

Outside the Menagerie, an older boy in expensive robes is leaning against the wall, tossing a Galleon. He looks at you like you are something on his shoe. "First-years," he drawls. "Lovely. Try not to cry in the Great Hall this year." He pockets the coin and strolls off. Someone nearby mutters his name: Cassius Thorne.

1.4 Ollivanders

READ ALOUD

A bell tinkles somewhere deep in the shop. The place smells of dust and old wood. Thousands of narrow boxes are piled to the ceiling. Then an old man with wide, pale eyes is simply there, as if he has been standing behind the counter all along. "Ah," he says softly. "I wondered when I would be seeing you."

Do one student at a time while the others watch. This is the moment the physical wands come out.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Players tab: on a student's card press **Wand questions**. Their phone and the TV show five questions. Read each question aloud as it appears, in Ollivander's voice. When they finish, a GM panel suggests the wood and core. Press **Give this wand**.

TIP

For comedy, before the real wand, hand them a wrong one and spin the **Wand misfire** wheel for them (Wheels tab). Then: "No, no. Not that one."

READ ALOUD

"Curious," Ollivander murmurs, as the wand warms in your hand and a ribbon of light curls from its tip. "Very curious. The wand chooses the wizard, you see. It is not always clear why. But I think we can expect great things from you. Or terrible ones. Often it is the same thing."

Wood	Bonus	Physical wand to hand over
Holly	+1 WIS	The holly wand
Yew	+1 CHA	The yew wand
Vine	+1 INT	The vine wand
Ash	+1 CON	The ash wand
Hawthorn	+1 DEX	The hawthorn wand
Oak	+1 STR	The oak wand

The core adds the rest: **phoenix feather** +1 spell damage and +2 max mana, **dragon heartstring** +2 spell damage, **unicorn hair** +4 max mana. The first wand costs 7 Galleons.

ON THE GM SCREEN

When everyone has a wand, press **Close shops**.

1.5 Platform Nine and Three-Quarters

ON THE GM SCREEN

Advance time to **The Hogwarts Express**. Move everyone to **Platform Nine and Three-Quarters**.

READ ALOUD

King's Cross station, eleven o'clock, and there is no platform nine and three-quarters. There is platform nine. There is platform ten. Between them is a solid brick barrier, and a family with an owl cage has just walked straight into it and vanished.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

"How do you get through?" Let them work it out. The Quill has no idea. Whoever explains it to the Quill earns the first kindness of the campaign.

READ ALOUD

You run at the wall. You do not hit it. Steam rolls over you, and through it you see a scarlet steam engine and a sign: Hogwarts Express, 11 o'clock. Students are hugging their families goodbye. Owls are screeching. A cat is escaping. You have arrived.

1.6 The Hogwarts Express

ON THE GM SCREEN

Move everyone to **The Hogwarts Express**. If you like, place the **covered painting** (People) in a corner of the map, and **Prefect Sinclair** in the corridor.

READ ALOUD

The train pulls out of the station and the city falls away into green hills. You have a compartment to yourselves. Somewhere down the corridor, a trolley is rattling closer, and a voice is calling, "Anything from the trolley, dears?"

Let them explore. The TV shows what they can do here: buy from the trolley, explore the carriages, peek at the covered painting.

- **The trolley:** anyone with Galleons can buy a Chocolate Frog or Bertie Bott's Beans. Use Players tab, **Give item**, and take the gold with the −5 button. Eating the beans spins the bean wheel on the TV by itself.
- **Prefect Sinclair** checks on her younger sibling and introduces herself to everyone. She is brisk, kind and clearly tired. If the Sinclair player talks to her privately, she admits she has been having bad dreams about paintings.
- **Cassius Thorne** passes the compartment and makes a point of greeting the Marlowe by surname, loudly.

The covered painting

READ ALOUD

In the last carriage, between the luggage racks, something large leans against the wall, wrapped in grey cloth and tied with cord. A painting, by the shape of it. There is no label. The cold in that carriage is the kind you feel in your teeth.

If the Quill goes near it, read this to them alone, or say it quietly to the whole table:

READ ALOUD

The cloth has slipped at one corner. Through the gap, you see a painted eye. It blinks. It follows you as you step back. When you look again, the cloth is in place, as if it never moved.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

“What do you do?” Nobody else saw it. The Quill can tell the others, or keep it to themselves.

1.7 The Sorting

ON THE GM SCREEN

Advance time to **The Welcome Feast**. Move everyone to **The Great Hall**.

READ ALOUD

The boats cross a black lake under a sky full of stars, and Hogwarts rises above you, every window lit. Inside, you are led into a hall so tall that its ceiling is the night sky itself. Thousands of candles float in the air. Four long tables full of students fall silent.

On a stool at the front sits a battered, patched old hat. A rip near its brim opens like a mouth, and it begins to sing.

READ ALOUD

“Put me on and let me look / beneath the face you show the room. / The brave of heart to red and gold, / the loyal to the badger’s home, /

the sharp of mind to blue and bronze, / the hungry-hearted, green and silver. / And if you think you know your place, / I promise you: I’ll know it better.”

Call the students up one at a time, in alphabetical order by family name: Blackwood, Fenwick, Marlowe, Quill, Sinclair, Thornbury.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Players tab: press **Sorting Hat** on that student’s card. Read each question aloud in the Hat’s voice as it appears on the TV. The last question asks if they want a particular house: if their wish is close to their best score, the Hat listens. Press the highlighted house to confirm, or choose another.

TIP

Give the Hat personality. Before the verdict, mutter something about their answers: “Brave, yes, but you chose the runes over the ticking box. Interesting.” The bigger the pause, the bigger the cheer.

READ ALOUD

The Hat shouts the name of your house, and one of the four tables explodes into applause. You stumble to your seat, your ears still ringing.

The Welcome Feast

READ ALOUD

Golden plates fill with food out of nowhere: roast potatoes, pies, puddings, things you have never seen before. Ghosts drift through the tables. When the last plate has cleared itself, the Headmaster rises.

"Welcome, all. A few notices. The Forbidden Forest is forbidden: the name was a clue. Curfew is at nine. Mr Filch reminds you that he has keys to every door in this castle, and he is not afraid to use them.

"And this year we have a gift. Professor Ashgrove, our new Defence teacher, has generously added to the castle's collection of portraits. Do say hello to them. Most of them like to talk."

Ashgrove stands and gives a warm wave. Everyone likes him at once. That is the point.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Table tab: press **Send all staff to their rooms**. Then move each student to their own **common room** and **Advance time**. The first school day begins.

TIP

Each common room has its own way in (see the appendix). Make every student do theirs once. It makes the houses feel real.

PART 2

The Week

Seven days, five blocks a day, and a ritual at the end of it.

How a day runs

Block	What the players do	Your job
Morning class	Go to class and play the minigame. Or skip it, and miss the lesson.	Start the class minigame.
Lunch	Two things: explore, talk to people, follow leads.	Read beats. Give quests on offer. People and clues place themselves.
Afternoon class	Second class of the day.	Start the class minigame.
Free time	Three things: explore, quests, puzzles, the library.	Same as Lunch.
Curfew	Two things: sneak around (risky) or rest.	Spin **Out after curfew** for anyone caught moving.

When you press **Advance time** past Curfew, a new morning begins: every student is restored to full HP and mana, and once-a-day abilities recharge. That is the long rest. If the party wants to keep going through the night, the clock does not care.

> **ON THE GM SCREEN**
>
> Every **Advance time** also moves the whole castle: staff, prefects, ghosts and Peeves go to their places for the new block, and that block's clues, chests, hazards and monsters appear on the map. The tables below say what happens; the **Conversation Book** says exactly who is where. See **The living castle** in Part 3.

Running a class

- When the clock reaches a class, the Day & class tab shows the class, professor, classroom and what it teaches.
- Tick who is attending. Anyone who is elsewhere (on a quest, in detention, asleep) misses it.
- Press **Start class minigame**. The professor and the students move into the classroom on the map, and every attending phone switches to the game.
- Each student gets two attempts. Passing teaches them the spell or item and gives 10 XP automatically. Failing twice means no lesson.
- Press **End class** when everyone is done.

> **READ ALOUD**
>
> *The professor sweeps in, and the room falls quiet. "Wands out," they say. "Today you are going to learn something that might one day save your life. Most of you will get it wrong the first time. That is allowed. Getting it wrong twice is less allowed."*

Running free time

Free blocks are where the story lives. Look at the TV with the players: the panel on the right lists what they can do here, the people present and the paths out. Ask what they want to do, then do it for them on the map.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

"It's lunchtime. You have about an hour before class. Where do you go?" Let them split up if they want. Move each group separately with the Move tick boxes.

TIP

If the table goes quiet, use a nudge: a ghost drifts past with gossip, Cassius picks a fight, or spin **Hogwarts surprises**.

Day 1: Welcome to Hogwarts

Block	What happens	Where
Morning class	**Charms** with Professor Flitwick. Teaches **Lumos**. Minigame: Wand Motion.	Charms classroom
Lunch	Prefect Sinclair finds the group and offers **Keep an Eye Out**.	Great Hall
Afternoon class	**Potions** with Professor Grimsby. Teaches **Pepperup Potion** (2). Minigame: Stir Timing.	Dungeons
Free time	Grimsby storms past furious: his store cupboard was raided. Offer **Stolen Ingredients**.	Dungeons
Curfew	**Beat:** a covered painting is hung in a corridor near the Undercroft.	Anywhere

READ ALOUD

Professor Grimsby does not look up when you come in. "Sit. Open your books. If anyone's cauldron explodes, they clean it up themselves." He is thin and grey and smells faintly of sulphur. Nobody likes him. You can tell he likes it that way.

Curfew beat

READ ALOUD

Late that night, two figures carry something large and wrapped down a stairway that most students do not know exists. They hang it in a dead-end corridor deep under the castle, below the dungeons. When they leave, the corridor is very, very quiet. Then the cloth stirs, though there is no wind.

If the Quill is awake, they wake with a jolt from a dream of a painted eye. Nobody else feels a thing.

Day 2: The first victim

Block	What happens	Where
Morning class	**Herbology** with Professor Longbottom. Teaches Mandrake care (1 Mandrake leaf). Minigame: Mandrake Repotting.	Greenhouses
Lunch	Ashgrove chats warmly with students and shows off his portraits. Everyone loves him.	Defence classroom
Afternoon class	**Defence Against the Dark Arts** with Professor Ashgrove. Teaches **Expelliarmus**. Minigame: Duel Reflexes.	Defence classroom
Free time	Dueling Club sign-ups with Flitwick: offer **Dueling Club Champion**.	Great Hall
Curfew	**Beat (cliffhanger):** Prefect Sinclair is found drained outside Ravenclaw Tower.	Ravenclaw common room

READ ALOUD

Professor Longbottom is already up to his elbows in soil when you arrive, laughing at something a plant has just done. "Earmuffs on, everyone! These are Mandrakes. Their cry won't kill you at this age, but it'll ruin your afternoon. Gently does it."

READ ALOUD

Professor Ashgrove's classroom is warm and bright and full of paintings: landscapes, old wizards, a ship in a storm. He is the kind of teacher who remembers your name on the first day. "Defence is not about fighting," he says. "It is about making sure the fight never reaches you. Now. Wands up."

Curfew beat: the cliffhanger

ON THE GM SCREEN

Move any students who are out to **Ravenclaw common room** (or wherever the scream would reach them). Place **Prefect Sinclair** on the map. After the reveal, pin the clue **"Every portrait near an attack had gone silent"** under **The covered painting** on the TV shows tab when they notice it.

READ ALOUD

A scream echoes down the corridor outside Ravenclaw Tower. By the time you get there, a crowd of students in pyjamas is standing in a ring around someone lying very still on the flagstones.

It is the Sinclair prefect. Her eyes are open. She is breathing. But she is grey, all of her, as if someone has painted her in shades of ash. Her wand lies beside her hand, and when a teacher picks it up, it crumbles like charcoal.

Along the corridor walls, every portrait is empty. Their frames hold only painted backgrounds. The people in them have gone somewhere else.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

Look at the Sinclair player. "What do you do?" Then stop. That is the end of session one.

Day 3: Shadows in the library

TIP

Start session two with a recap. Ask the players to tell you what has happened so far, in their own words. Fill in only what they forget.

Block	What happens	Where
Morning class	**Transfiguration** with Professor Vance. Teaches **Avifors**. Minigame: Matching Pairs.	Transfiguration classroom
Lunch	**Beat:** a second student is drained near the library. Longbottom offers **Wake the Sleepers**.	Library
Afternoon class	**Care of Magical Creatures** with Professor Scamander. Teaches creature handling (2 Creature treats). Minigame: Befriend the Beast. Offer **Where is Bramble?**	Gamekeeper's hut
Free time	The library opens up. Place the Restricted Section's first diary page if you are running the Painter's Bargain.	Library
Curfew	Anyone sneaking out spins **Out after curfew**. Filch means detention, and that starts **The Old Cup**. Hide **The Hungry Trunk** in the Trophy Room as a Locked chest.	Anywhere

READ ALOUD

The second victim is a fourth-year, slumped against the library shelves with a book still open in her lap. Grey, all of her. The librarian is white with shock. The portraits in this corridor are silent too, and one of them has a smear of fresh paint across its frame, as if something climbed out in a hurry.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Clues to pin now (TV shows tab), when the players find them: **Grimsby's store cupboard was raided** (under Grimsby), **Every portrait near an attack had gone silent** (under the painting).

READ ALOUD

Professor Scamander keeps a battered old suitcase by her feet at all times. Something inside it occasionally thumps. "Creatures are not dangerous," she says. "People who do not understand them are dangerous. Today we learn to understand."

Day 4: The missing page

Block	What happens	Where
Morning class	**Potions** with Grimsby. Teaches **Wiggenweld Potion** (2). Minigame: Stir Timing, harder.	Dungeons
Lunch	Cassius is seen in the courtyard with half of an old map. The Fenwick should get **The Other Half**.	Courtyard
Afternoon class	**Flying Lessons** with Madam Hooch. Teaches broom flying. Minigame: Broom Dodge.	Quidditch Pitch
Free time	**Beat:** the only page about Corvin Vale vanishes from the Restricted Section, unless the players already took it.	Restricted Section
Curfew	The Painted Double appears in the story tonight. Open with a round of the **Painted Double** party game first (Part 3). Also a good night for the Torch Wall or the Moving Staircases if the party is exploring.	Anywhere

READ ALOUD

Madam Hooch blows her whistle hard enough to rattle the stands. "Right hand over the broom and say UP! Not up, not please, UP! And if anyone flies into the hoops, I am not picking you up."

ON THE GM SCREEN

Clues to pin as found: **Ashgrove's classroom has more paintings every day**, **Filch has keys to every corridor**, **Cassius was seen with half of an old map**, and **A page about Corvin Vale** if they reach it in time. Place it as an item, **Torn page about Corvin Vale**, in the Restricted Section early in the day.

READ ALOUD

The page is old and brittle. Most of it is about a painter named Corvin Vale, who lived three hundred years ago and painted portraits so lifelike that people said his subjects sometimes left their frames. In his last years, he became obsessed with one idea: that a painting never grows old. The final line has been underlined so hard that the quill tore through the paper. "I will finish myself."

Day 5: Suspicion

Block	What happens	Where
Morning class	**Charms** with Flitwick. Teaches **Alohomora**. Minigame: Wand Motion, harder. Students who skip this will struggle with the Time-Turner and chests.	Charms classroom
Lunch	Grimsby is seen carrying armfuls of ingredients to his office. Suspicious?	Dungeons
Afternoon class	**Defence** with Ashgrove. Teaches **Protego**. Minigame: Duel Reflexes, harder.	Defence classroom
Free time	The Room of Requirement can appear if they think to look. Offer **The Turning Lock**.	Grand Staircase
Curfew	**Beat:** Grimsby is caught standing over a third victim.	Dungeons

Curfew beat: the red herring

READ ALOUD

In the dungeon corridor, a third student lies grey and still. Kneeling over them, wand raised, is Professor Grimsby. When he sees you, his face goes from shock to fury. "Back to your common rooms! Now!" In his other hand is a small bottle of something glowing faintly gold.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Pin **Grimsby was found standing over the third victim** under Grimsby. Do not clear him yet. If the players investigate his office or the bottle, give them **Grimsby was secretly brewing a draught to wake the victims**, which clears him.

TIP

This is the moment the players will want to accuse Grimsby. Let them. Their accusation is wrong, and finding that out is half the fun. Call an accusation vote and keep it a **hunch**: he is stamped **Accused**. Mark him **Cleared** when the truth comes out. This is the end of session two.

Day 6: Hogsmeade

Block	What happens	Where
Morning class	No classes. Hogsmeade visit. Open the shops if you like.	Hogsmeade
Lunch	The Three Broomsticks: rumours about a painter, and a ghost who saw "a figure step out of a frame".	Three Broomsticks
Afternoon class	No classes. The Shrieking Shack holds a diary page for the Painter's Bargain.	Shrieking Shack
Free time	**Beat:** Ashgrove's eyes flicker with paint. The truth can come out tonight.	Defence classroom
Curfew	The covered painting may whisper its bargain to one student. Offer **The Painter's Bargain**.	Undercroft corridor

READ ALOUD

Hogsmeade is all snowy roofs and warm windows. The sweet shop smells of sugar and chocolate. In the Three Broomsticks, the landlady puts down two frothing Butterbeers and leans in. "Strange business up at the school, I hear. Kids going grey. My gran used to tell a story about a painter who did that. Vale, his name was. Don't go looking for him, dears."

Free time beat: Ashgrove's eyes

READ ALOUD

Ashgrove is marking essays alone in his classroom when you pass the door. He looks up and smiles his warm smile, and for just a moment, his eyes are not eyes. They are brushstrokes: thick, wet, swirling paint. He blinks, and they are ordinary again. "Can I help you?" he asks. Every painting in the room is watching you.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Pin **Ashgrove's eyes looked like brushstrokes** and, if they look closely at his sleeve, **Flecks of wet paint on Ashgrove's sleeve**. If the players put it together tonight, let them confront him. If not, it all comes out on Day 7.

Day 7: The seventh night

Block	What happens	Where
Morning class	**Transfiguration** with Vance. Teaches **Incendio**. This is the spell that burns Paint Wraiths and Vale's canvas.	Transfiguration classroom
Lunch	Ashgrove does not appear at lunch. His classroom is locked. His paintings are gone.	Great Hall
Afternoon class	Classes cancelled. The castle is on lockdown. Teachers patrol the corridors.	Common rooms
Free time	The last chance to prepare: brew, rest, find the Time-Turner, solve the Trials. Before they go down, hold the **final accusation** (Part 3): naming the painting weakens the bosses.	Anywhere
Curfew	**Beat: the ritual.** If Vale is not stopped before this block ends, he walks free and the game is lost.	The Undercroft

READ ALOUD

At breakfast, the Headmaster stands and the hall falls silent. "As of this afternoon, the castle is closed. Students will remain in their common rooms. No exceptions." Every portrait in the Great Hall is empty. Somewhere far below, so deep you feel it in your feet more than hear it, something is humming.

Turn to Part 6, the Finale, when the players head for the Undercroft. The Day & class tab warns you when you reach the final block.

TIP

If the players use the Time-Turner, everyone returns to Day 1 morning with all their XP, spells and items, and you replay the week with them knowing everything. The beats happen again unless they stop them. It can only happen once.

PART 3

Running the Systems

The rules in one place, for when a player asks "can I…?"

Checks

When a player tries something that could fail, ask for a check: a d20 plus one stat bonus, against a difficulty. They roll on the **Dice** tab (pick d20 and the stat). The result appears on the TV.

Difficulty	DC	Example
Very easy	5	Climbing a low wall, remembering a professor's name
Easy	10	Sneaking past a dozing portrait, calming a nervous owl
Medium	13	Picking a lock, lying to a prefect, finding a book fast
Hard	16	Sneaking past Filch, reading an ancient rune
Very hard	19	Lying to the Headmaster, outrunning a Thornback Boar

Stat	Use it for
STR	Forcing doors, carrying, holding on, punching
DEX	Sneaking, dodging, flying, picking locks, quick hands
CON	Resisting poison, cold, curses, staying awake
INT	Potions, research, puzzles, remembering lessons, ancient chests
WIS	Noticing things, reading people, creatures, sensing danger
CHA	Persuading, lying, charming teachers, bluffing Filch

- **Advantage:** roll two d20s and keep the higher. Give it when something helps: a good plan, the right spell, a friend helping.
- **Disadvantage:** roll two and keep the lower. Give it when something hinders: darkness, panic, a broken wand.
- **Natural 20** always succeeds in a fight. **Natural 1** always fails. Outside fights, describe something wonderful or disastrous.

Fights and duels

- Place monsters on the map (Table tab, **Place on this map**, Monsters). Only students standing in that place take part.
- Press **Start fight**. Everyone rolls initiative automatically and the TV shows the turn order.
- **A student's turn:** their phone glows "Your turn!". On the Dice tab they choose a spell or Improvised attack, pick a target, roll d20 to hit against the target's Defence, then roll the spell's own damage die. The monster's HP drops by itself.
- **A monster's turn:** press **Select** on it, choose who it attacks, press **Attack**. The app rolls against that student's Defence.
- Press **Next turn** to move on. When it is over, **End and share XP** removes the beaten monsters and gives their XP to everyone who fought.

- A student at 0 HP is **knocked out**, not dead. They are first-years. A potion or a new morning brings them back.

READ ALOUD

Describe the hit, not the numbers. Not "you deal six damage" but: "Your Stupefy catches it square in the chest, and it skids back across the flagstones, hissing."

Spells

Spell	Mana	Roll	Does	Learned
Improvised attack	0	d20 + STR, then d4	Punch, kick, throw something	Always
Lumos	1	none	Light; reveals invisible ink; Devil's Snare hates it	Day 1 Charms
Avifors	2	d4	Birds distract for that many rounds	Day 3 Transfiguration
Alohomora	2	d20 + INT check	Opens locks; advantage on chests	Day 5 Charms
Protego	3	d6	Blocks that much damage from the next attack	Day 5 Defence
Expelliarmus	3	d20 + DEX to hit	On a hit, the target's next attack misses	Day 2 Defence
Stupefy	4	d20 + INT, then d8	Damage (plus spell damage bonus)	Sinclairs start with it
Incendio	5	d20 + INT, then d10	Damage; burns Paint Wraiths and canvas	Day 7 Transfiguration
Avada Kedavra	10	d20 + CHA to hit	Kills outright; bosses take 20	Secret (see Part 4)

Teaching other spells

ON THE GM SCREEN

Spells tab: pick a student, then **Teach** any spell. It appears on their Dice tab with its own dice, ready to cast. **Remove** takes it away. Tick **Announce on the TV** for a public moment, or leave it off for secrets. For Expecto Patronum, type their Patronus form first (otter, stag, hare…); it shows on their spell card and on the TV.

Spell	Mana	Roll	Does
Wingardium Leviosa	2	d20 + INT check	Levitates an object
Accio	3	d20 + INT check	Summons a named object
Reparo	1	none	Mends something broken
Aguamenti	2	none	Water; puts out fires
Finite Incantatem	2	d20 + WIS check	Ends a spell or curse
Episkey	3	d6	Heals that much (you apply it)
Flipendo	2	d20 + INT, then d6	Knockback damage
Rictusempra	2	d20 + CHA to hit	Target loses its next turn laughing
Diffindo	3	d20 + DEX, then d6	Cuts; damage
Riddikulus	3	d20 + CHA, then d10	Damage, but only to Boggarts
Silencio	3	d20 + CHA to hit	Target can't cast next turn
Glacius	4	d20 + INT, then d8	Freezing damage
Confundo	4	d20 + CHA to hit	Target attacks the wrong person (you decide)

Spell	Mana	Roll	Does
Immobulus	4	d20 + WIS to hit	Frozen in place for a round
Petrificus Totalus	5	d20 + INT to hit	Target skips its next turn
Bombarda	7	d20 + INT, then 2d8	Explosive damage (advanced)
Expecto Patronum	8	d20 + WIS, then d12	Drives back dark creatures (advanced, Year 3)

Custom spells: at the bottom of the Spells tab, give it a name, icon, mana, type (attack with damage, attack with an effect, check, roll, or no roll), stat and dice. It works exactly like a library spell. To make a custom spell stun or silence, add the status by hand when it hits (see Status effects below).

Monsters

Monster	HP	Defence	Attack	XP	Notes
Cornish Pixie	4	12	+3, d4	5	Come in swarms
Devil's Snare	14	10	+4, d6	15	Hates light and fire
Boggart	10	12	+3, d6	20	Laughter hurts it
Dueling Club rival	14	12	+3, d6	15	For duels
Paint Wraith	12	13	+4, d6	25	Vale's servant. Fire burns it
Thornback Boar	22	13	+5, d8	40	Forbidden Forest. Creature treats or a Thornbury can calm it and end the fight
Mountain Troll	30	11	+6, d10	50	Slow, hits like a wall
Ashgrove (possessed)	45	14	+5, d8+2	100	Boss, phase 1
Corvin Vale	60	15	+6, d10+2	200	Boss, phase 2

The reaction duel (the finale)

The two bosses, Ashgrove and Corvin Vale, fight you in a real-time duel. It is still turn by turn, but when the boss casts a spell at a student, that student has a few seconds to react on their phone. Everything else about the fight stays the same.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Select the boss on the map. **Reaction duel** is ticked by default. Choose who to cast at, then press one of the three spell buttons. The TV and the student's phone light up with the spell and a countdown. The app settles it by itself when they react or time runs out, and the result shows on the TV for a few seconds.

Spell colour	The right reaction	If they get it in time
Red	Shield	The damage is halved
Blue	Dodge	The boss rolls its attack with disadvantage
Gold	Counter	The spell misses and rebounds on the boss for 1d6 (plus their spell damage bonus)

- **Wrong button, too slow, or no answer:** a normal attack, no extra punishment.
- **Time to react:** 4 seconds, a quarter of a second more or less for each point of DEX bonus (never under 2). Your screen shows each student's time next to their name.

- **One reaction per round:** each student can react once per round. If they have already used it, their phone tells them to brace.
- **Protego saves:** any other student in the room who knows Protego and has 3 mana gets a **Shield them** button. The fastest one blocks 1d6 of the damage, pays 3 mana and uses their own reaction for the round. A true team moment.
- **Phase 2 is faster:** Corvin Vale gives 25% less time. Tick **Feint** before casting and the spell shows a false colour first, then switches. Anyone who reacts to the false colour is fooled.
- **His spells:** Ashgrove casts Stupefy (red), Paint Lash (blue) and Bombarda Maxima (gold, 2d8). Vale casts Varnish Hex (red), Brushstroke Blade (blue) and Crucio (gold), which puts the Cruciatus Curse on whoever it hits.
- **Plain attack:** the normal Attack button still works for a quick hit with no reaction. Untick Reaction duel to switch it off for that boss.

> **TIP**
>
> Tell them before the finale: the colours from Duel Reflexes in Defence class are how you survive tonight. Then save the gold spell and the feint for the moments that matter. A fooled Counter is the best groan of the night.

Status effects

Some spells leave something behind on the target: a bleed, a stun, a hex. The app tracks them and counts them down. They show as small icons on the map tokens, in the turn order on your screen and the TV, and on the player's phone.

Status	What it does	Usual length
Bleed	2 damage at the start of each of their turns	3 turns
Burning	2 damage at the start of each of their turns	2 turns
Stunned	They lose their turn	1 turn
Hung Upside Down	They lose their turn and drop what they are holding	1 turn
Silenced	No spells. A player's spell buttons lock; they can still use Improvised attack	1 to 2 turns
Fear	Disadvantage. A frightened monster rolls its attacks twice and keeps the lower; a frightened player's phone switches to Disadvantage	1 turn
Cruciatus	Loses the turn and takes 1d4 each turn, until you lift it	Until lifted
Imperius	Under the caster's control for a turn: you decide what they do	1 turn
Blood Shield	The next hit on them does nothing, then the shield breaks	Until it blocks a hit

- **When they happen:** when you press **Next turn**, the new combatant's statuses go off first. Damage comes off their HP, the feed says if they lose the turn (press Next turn again), and anything that has run out wears off.
- **Year 1 spells that use them:** Petrificus Totalus, Immobulus and Rictusempra stun for a turn on a hit. Silencio silences for a turn.

- **By hand:** select any token or student on the map and use **Add a status**. Tap a status to remove it, for example when Finite Incantatem works or the story ends it. The same controls are on each student's card on the Players tab.

Dark magic and Corruption

The series has a spellbook of darker and later magic: Half-Blood Prince jinxes, blood magic, curses and Fiendfyre. Each spell unlocks in a set year at a set level, matching the year levels (Year 1 is levels 1 to 5, Year 2 is 6 to 10, and so on). In Year 1 they are all locked, so the players can't learn them yet. They are in the app now so they are ready for later years.

> **ON THE GM SCREEN**
>
> **Spells** tab, **Dark arts, blood magic and later years**. Each spell shows its year and level lock, its dice, the status it causes, its Corruption cost and what happens on a natural 20 or a natural 1. To bend the rules for a story moment, tick **Let me teach locked spells anyway**.

Corruption

Dark spells add Corruption to whoever casts them, from 0 to 10, whether they hit or miss. It carries over into the next year. It shows on the student's card for you, and on their phone once it is above 0. Light magic or a good deed can take 1 away: use the **−1** button, your call.

Corruption	What happens
3 or more	−1 on persuasion rolls with good-aligned NPCs
5 or more	Portraits and ghosts refuse to help this character
7 or more	The boss may try to turn this character (you roll for it)

These are yours to apply when they come up; the card lists the ones that are active. In Year 1 the only way to gain Corruption is the Killing Curse, which adds 5. That is enough to make the portraits fall silent. It hits a Blackwood hardest, because their family power is talking to portraits.

Villain spells

Crucio, Imperio and Avada Kedavra from the spellbook can never be learned by players. They belong to the enemy.

- **To cast one:** select the monster on the map, open **Villain spell**, choose the curse and the student, then press **Cast**. It rolls the monster's attack against the student's Defence.
- **Crucio:** on a hit, the student is put under the Cruciatus Curse. They lose their turns and take 1d4 each turn until you remove it, when the caster lets go, is hit or is beaten.
- **Imperio:** on a hit, the student rolls d20 + WIS to fight it off (15 or more). If they fail, they are under the Imperius Curse for one turn and you decide what they do.
- **Avada Kedavra** is for a cutscene only: read it out, never roll it. It is greyed out in the list on purpose.

> **TIP**
>
> Ashgrove or Corvin Vale casting Crucio in the finale is the moment the game stops feeling like school. Use it once, and let the others save their friend.

Mimics

Place them from the Table tab: **Place on this map**, then **Mimics**. The players can never tell a mimic from the real thing until it springs.

Mimic	Disguise	Stats	Its trick
The Hungry Trunk	An ordinary Locked chest	30 HP, Defence 13, +5, d8, 60 XP	Every bite swallows a random item from the target's bag. Each item: it grows bigger and gains 5 max HP. Potions it swallows heal it. With 3 or more items inside, its bite adds 1d6. When beaten, it spits everything out on the floor, plus its hoard of Galleons.
The Painted Double	Any person you choose	26 HP, Defence 14, +4, d6, 60 XP	On its turn it casts the last spell that hit it back at whoever cast it, for the same damage. Incendio does double damage to it: fire burns paint.

- **The Hungry Trunk springs itself** the moment anyone tries to open it.
- If you made your own jump scare video (*public/video/jumpscare.mp4*), it plays on the TV instead of the drawn maw. Phones still buzz and flash red.
- **The Painted Double waits for you.** When a player talks to it or touches it, select it and press **Spring the mimic**.
- The TV goes black, a monster maw lunges out with a scream, every phone buzzes and flashes red, and a fight starts with the mimic acting first. A Sinclair still goes first: they cannot be surprised.
- Selecting a sprung mimic on the GM screen shows what it has swallowed, and who the Double will mirror next.
- Story items (the serpent key, the map half, diary pages, ring clues) can never be swallowed.

READ ALOUD

The lid creaks. For a moment there is nothing but dark inside. Then the dark has teeth.

READ ALOUD

Professor Flitwick smiles up at you. It is a perfectly ordinary smile, until it keeps going, wider and wider, past his ears, and his face runs like wet paint.

TIP

One mimic per play day is plenty. Good spots: the Trophy Room during detention, a chest in the Restricted Section, the Double as Prefect Sinclair after she is drained (cruel, and unforgettable), or the Double as a ghost in Hogsmeade. Throwing a Chocolate Frog or Pumpkin Pasty at the Trunk is a clever distraction: let it skip a turn eating.

House points

ON THE GM SCREEN

Header: **Points**. Type a reason (optional), then tap −10, −5, +5 or +10 beside a student. The TV announces it with the reason.

Award	For
+5	Good roleplay, a clever idea, kindness, helping another house
+10	Solving a puzzle, a brave rescue, a brilliant plan, passing a hard lesson first time
−5	Cheek to a teacher, breaking a small rule, getting caught somewhere silly
−10	Being caught by Filch after curfew (the wheel does this for you), fighting in corridors

TIP

House points are the easiest way to reward players for the things you want more of. Give them out often and say why out loud.

Wheels

ON THE GM SCREEN

Wheels tab: choose a wheel and who is spinning, press **Spin**. It spins on the TV and its result applies to that student when it lands. **Re-spin (Felix)** is for Felix Felicis.

Wheel	Use it when
Bertie Bott's Beans	Someone eats the beans (it spins by itself)
Potion brewing	Brewing outside class, or as drama during Potions
Out after curfew	Anyone moving around during Curfew. Filch means −10 points and detention
Wand misfire	The wrong wand at Ollivanders, or a cursed moment
Portrait gossip	The Blackwood breaks a rule near a portrait (their drawback)
They heard you hiss	Someone hears the Marlowe speak Parseltongue (their drawback)
Forbidden Forest	Each time the party moves through the forest
Hogwarts surprises	Whenever the table goes quiet
Did anyone see?	After the Killing Curse (it spins by itself, without naming the caster)

Chests, items and hazards

Place them from the Table tab: **Place on this map**, then Chests, Items or Hazards. They land on the current map. Tap one and tap the map to move it.

Chest	Lock	Holds
Small chest	DEX 8	3 to 10 Galleons and a sweet or potion
Locked chest	DEX 13	10 to 25 Galleons and two potions or tricks
Ancient chest	INT 16	25 to 60 Galleons and two rare things
Cursed chest	DEX 14	20 to 40 Galleons and something rare. Failing costs 4 HP

Players open chests from the **Here** tab on their phones. Each student gets one try per chest, so a failure means someone else has to try. Alohomora gives advantage. Selecting a chest on the GM screen shows its loot.

Items on the ground glint on the map. The first student in the room to tap **Pick up** gets it. This is how you hide clues, diary pages and ring clues.

Hazard	When triggered
Shelf of paint jars	Destroys every Paint Wraith here and burns bosses for 5
Cracked mirror	Reflected magic hits bosses for 8
Cold braziers	Heals every student here by 5
Ritual circle	Bosses here lose 3 Defence
Vale’s empty canvas	15 damage to bosses
Cracked pillar	6 damage to every enemy here

Hazards show on the TV under “Here” as things the players could do. When they choose one, tap it on the GM screen and press its action. Ask for a check first if it should be hard.

The six families

Family	Gift (always)	Once a day	Drawback
Blackwood	Portraits speak freely	A portrait must answer one question truthfully	Portraits gossip (spin Portrait gossip)
Sinclair	Can’t be surprised; knows Stupefy	Re-roll a d20 in a fight	Needs a WIS check to walk away from insults
Fenwick	Has half the Marauder’s Map, but not the words	Opens the map on the TV by voice, once a day	The missing half (The Other Half)
Thornbury	Creatures never attack first; advantage to calm them	A creature tells what it has seen	Will risk anything for a creature
Quill	Sees through disguises and illusions	Ask: what here is hidden or enchanted?	Unwanted visions
Marlowe	Parseltongue; serpent doors open; has the serpent key	A snake scouts, guards or carries a message	People fear it (spin They heard you hiss)

When a student taps their ability on the phone, the TV announces it. You decide what they learn. Abilities recharge each morning.

The living castle

Everyone in the castle keeps a timetable: the staff, prefects, Filch, Peeves, the ghost, the centaur, even the covered painting. There are 7 days with 5 blocks each, and every person has a set place in every one. When you press **Advance time**, the app moves them all there for you and puts out that block's clues, chests, items, hazards and monsters. Passing monsters disappear when the block ends unless a fight is still going.

- **The castle this block** panel sits under the clock on the Day & class tab. It lists who is where, what just appeared, and which quests are on offer right now.
- **Quests on offer:** press **Give to everyone** once the players actually talk to that person. On the TV, people with a quest show a little scroll.
- **Conversations:** tap any person in the panel, or their token on the map, to see their voice, what they want and what they can say today. Pin a clue or give a quest straight from there.
- **Moving people yourself** still works. They stay put until their next scheduled move. Untick **Move everyone automatically** to run a block entirely by hand, and press **Put everyone in place now** to snap back to the timetable.
- The Time-Turner resets the castle to Day 1 morning along with everything else.

Missed quests arrive by owl

Every quest is on offer for a few blocks. On its last block the panel marks it **Last chance**. If nobody picks it up, the person who would have given it sends an owl at the start of the next block, and the quest goes straight onto the players' phones. The TV only shows that an owl arrived, so secret quests stay secret. The letters are spread out, about one a block, so nobody is buried in post.

- Most letters go to everyone. **The Other Half** goes to the Fenwick student, and **The Painter's Bargain** to one student chosen at random.
- **The Trials Beneath** never comes by owl. The players have to find the serpent door themselves.
- Untick **Send missed quests by owl** to stop this. Anything missed then waits in the panel with a **Send them by owl now** button.

> **TIP**
>
> An owl is a second chance, not a punishment. Read the letter aloud in the sender's voice when the player opens it. The full letters are in the Conversation Book.

The scene counter

Lunch gives the players time for **2** things, free time **3**, curfew **2**. A no-class block, like the Hogsmeade trip or the lockdown, gives 3. Classes have no counter. The TV shows the time left as little gold lights next to the clock. Press **Scene done** after each thing they do. On the last one the GM screen reminds you to warn them, and at zero the TV says the bell is ringing. **+1** gives them more time, **Undo** takes a press back, and **Hide** removes the counter for that block.

One **scene** means going somewhere and doing one meaningful thing: a proper conversation, searching a room, opening a chest, shopping, a fight, a puzzle, or sneaking somewhere. Walking through a place on the way is free. Somewhere far, like the Forbidden Forest, takes a scene just to reach. Fights and puzzles end the block. A split party gets one budget per group; alternate one scene at a time between them.

TIP

The full timetable and every conversation are printed in the companion **Conversation Book**. Keep it open beside this one: this book tells you the story, that one tells you who is where and what they will say.

The suspect board and the accusation

The suspect board is the players' detective wall on the TV: six suspects, and every clue they find pinned under one of them. It is a tracker, not a trap: pinning a clue or stamping someone does nothing by itself. It is there so the players can see the case and argue about it.

ON THE GM SCREEN

TV shows tab. **Suspect board** puts it on the TV and locks the phones; **Back to the map** takes it off. Each clue has a dropdown: move it from Not found yet to the suspect it belongs under (the right one has a tick). Each suspect has an Open / Cleared / Accused stamp. You can also pin clues from a person's conversation.

The accusation vote

Press **Call an accusation vote** on the same tab. Every phone shows the six suspects with their portraits and each player taps the one they think is behind it all; the TV shows who has voted. Press **Show the votes on the TV**, and then choose how it ends:

- **Keep it a hunch.** The table's pick is stamped **Accused** on the board and nothing is revealed. Use it as often as you like mid-week, for example when they all turn on Grimsby on Day 5.
- **Make it the final accusation.** The TV reveals the truth: it was **the covered painting**. Everyone who named it gets **+40 XP and +20 house points**; anyone who named **Ashgrove** (the hands, not the mind) gets half. If the table as a whole got it, **every boss loses 10 HP**, including ones already on the map. Use this once, just before the finale.

TIP

When to use it. Day 2 curfew: show the board for the first time after the cliffhanger. Day 3: show it during the recap. Day 5 curfew: let them vote a hunch on Grimsby, then clear him when they find his draught. Day 7 free time, before they go down to the Undercroft: the final accusation. A correct answer makes the finale fairer; a wrong one makes it harder, and both make a good story.

Sound, music and the main event

- **Sound effects** play on the TV by themselves: spells, hits, natural 20s, house points, level-ups, the wheel ticking, chests, page turns, the clock bell at dawn.
- **Music:** pick a track from the menu in the GM header. It loops on the TV and fades between tracks. Suggested: Diagon Alley for the prologue, Great Hall for feasts, Mystery for free time, Forbidden Forest outdoors, Battle for fights, Undercroft for the finale, Victory for the House Cup.
- **Main event:** every phone locks with "Main Event: pay attention to the screen" during the opening, puzzles, the suspect board, awards and the House Cup. Press **Main event** to lock them for any big moment yourself, and again to release.

> **TIP**
>
> Use the main event lock for every story beat. A locked phone is the clearest possible signal that something important is happening.

The Painted Double (party game)

An Imposter-style game for the whole table. Everyone in the round gets the same secret word on their phone, except one player, the **Double**, who gets only your hint. Going round the table, each player says **one word** about the secret, out loud. Then everyone votes on their phone for who they think the Double is.

> **ON THE GM SCREEN**
>
> **Double** tab (the mask). Tick who is playing (3 or more), leave the Double and the word on random (or pick them), and press **Start the round**. Your screen shows the word, the hint and who the Double is. Press **Start the vote** when everyone has had a turn or two, then **Reveal on the TV**.

- **Your words:** type them in on the Double tab, each with a hint for the Double. Use **Add lots at once** to paste a list, one per line: *Owlery | Feathers*. The list is saved to your account, only you can see it, and played words are not picked again at random until you reset them.
- **Good words** are things the table knows well: places, people, spells and items from the game. **Good hints** point the right way without giving it away: *Library* could have the hint *Quiet*.
- **The vote:** the player with the most votes is accused. A tie means nobody is caught, and the Double escapes.
- **Caught?** The Double gets one guess at the word. Let them say it out loud, then press **They guessed it** (the Double steals the win) or **Wrong guess**.
- **Rewards:** one tap gives +5 house points to everyone who voted right, or +10 to a Double who got away with it. You can also have the covered painting send the Double an owl. Vale likes people who can hide.
- **Secrecy:** each card can only be read by its own player. Nobody can peek at someone else's phone through the game, so tell them to keep their screens to themselves.

> **TIP**
>
> Use it as a scene choice: during curfew in a common room, "play a round" is the safe thing to do instead of sneaking out. And on Day 4 curfew, when the real Painted Double appears in the story, open with a round of this first. The game they have been laughing at becomes the threat.

The Marauder's Map

The Fenwick starts with half of the Marauder's Map. Opened, it fills the TV with the castle drawn in ink, and everyone in it walks about as footsteps with their names beside them: students, teachers, ghosts, creatures. When someone changes room, their footsteps walk the corridors to get there. It also marks every chest and item lying around, which nothing else in the game shows.

- **The words:** the Fenwick doesn't know them at first. They are scratched in runes along the torn edge: run the puzzle **The Torn Edge** (Puzzles tab) whenever the Fenwick studies the map. The answer is the password.
- **Opening it:** the holder taps **Open** on the map in their Bag, presses **Speak to the map** and says the words out loud. The phone listens. Get them wrong and the map answers back with an insult. A phone that can't listen can type the words instead.

- **Closing it:** say the closing words, *Mischief managed*, or tap **Just fold it up**.
- **The drawback:** it opens **once per day** and the ink **fades after 60 seconds**, so the table has to read it fast. Agree what you are looking for before you open it.
- **Half a map:** one half shows only the left side of the castle: the Great Hall, Dungeons, Kitchens, the lake and the way to Hogsmeade. Cassius Thorne has the other half: the staircase, classrooms, towers and the grounds by the forest.
- **The whole map:** when one student holds both halves, it shows everything, and also gives away three hidden places: the Undercroft, the Restricted Section and the Shrieking Shack. The Room of Requirement never appears on it.
- **The map never lies:** a mimic shows by its true name, so the Painted Double disguised as a teacher appears as *The Painted Double*. The covered painting's name won't settle; it flickers as *C— V—*. Ghosts, Peeves and the painting leave no footprints.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Table tab, **Marauder's Map** box. See who holds which half and whether it has been used today. **Show the Fenwick half** or **Show the whole map** open it on the TV without the words (it doesn't use up the day). **Let it wake again today** resets the daily use. Tick **Peek at the whole map** to watch everyone's footsteps yourself at any time; only you see it.

TIP

The first time it opens, stay quiet and let the ink spread. Then point out one set of footsteps nobody expected to see.

Owl Post

A private letter from you to one player. Use it for anything secret: a family secret coming true, a vision, a portrait's honest answer, a whisper from the painting.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Owl Post tab: pick the student, choose who it is from (or type anyone), write the letter, press **Send**. Templates fill in common secrets. The sent list shows whether it has been opened.

- Their phone: an owl swoops in and drops a sealed letter. They tap the wax seal to read it. It stays in **Owl Post** on their Sheet.
- The TV only says "An owl swoops in with a sealed letter for Zibby…". Everyone knows a secret happened. Nobody knows what.
- Only that player can read it. The database itself enforces this, so even a curious friend with the site open cannot peek.

TIP

Owls are perfect for the Quill's visions, the Blackwood's portrait questions, Vale's whispers from Day 5 on, and one cruel letter to the Sinclair after the cliffhanger: "It was the painting. It took my colour. Find it. Love, your sister."

Levels

Each year has its own level range: **Year 1 is levels 1 to 5**, Year 2 is 5 to 10, and so on to Year 7. XP stops at the top of the year's range. Every new level gives **+4 max HP and +2 max mana** automatically. Give a stat point by hand if you like (Players tab, Edit stats and limits).

Level	1	2	3	4	5
XP needed	0	100	250	450	700

XP comes from classes (10 each), fights (shared monster XP), quests and the XP buttons on each card.

Special rules

Detention

Players tab: **Detention**, or Filch on the curfew wheel. The student is moved to the Trophy Room with Filch, and **The Old Cup** quietly appears on their phone. Make it fun: Filch makes them polish the trophies, which is exactly how they find the engraving.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *"Polish them," Filch growls, dumping a rag and a tin of something foul in front of you. "All of them. By hand. And if I find a single fingerprint, you're back here tomorrow." He shuffles out, muttering. You are alone with three hundred years of cups and shields.*

The Killing Curse

Teach it from Players tab, **Edit stats and limits**, **Teach the Killing Curse (secret)**. Only one character can ever learn it. They automatically get an owl from the painting telling them they have it, and that Vale will be watching through their eyes. Nothing appears on the TV. Casting it adds 5 Corruption (see Dark magic and Corruption).

Expulsion

Only the Killing Curse can get a student expelled, through the secret wheel. An expelled student cannot attend classes. You can reinstate them from Players tab, **Edit stats and limits**, if the story earns it.

The Time-Turner

Found through **The Turning Lock**. When the players use it, press **Use the Time-Turner** on the Day & class tab. Everyone returns to Day 1 morning keeping all XP, spells and items. Then it cracks forever.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *The tiny hourglass spins in your hand, faster and faster, and the world spins with it: days unwinding, candles un-burning, the grey drained faces of your friends filling back with colour. Then it is morning. Day one. The bell for breakfast is ringing. The Time-Turner gives a small, sad crack, and goes still.*

PART 4

Quests

Eight quests to hand out, and four that stay secret until earned.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Quests tab: tick who the quest is for and press **Give quest**. Tick objectives as they happen. **Complete** hands out the rewards automatically. Secret quests sit under **Secret quests** and only appear on phones once you press **Reveal to them**.

The main quest

The Hollow Heir

When: Give it to everyone after the first victim (Day 2, Curfew).

READ ALOUD

Somebody, or something, is feeding on the students of Hogwarts. The teachers are frightened. The portraits are hiding. If anyone is going to find out what is happening, it is going to be you.

- **1.** Find out what is draining the students (the paintings, Day 2 to 4).
- **2.** Learn the name of the painted man (Corvin Vale: the library page, the Three Broomsticks, the diary).
- **3.** Find the way into the Undercroft (The Trials Beneath, or the Marlowe key and Parseltongue).
- **4.** Stop the ritual before the seventh night ends (the finale).

Reward: 150 XP each and 50 house points each. Completing it is winning the campaign.

Side quests

Keep an Eye Out

When: Day 1, Lunch. Prefect Sinclair, to the Sinclair (and friends).

READ ALOUD

"I'm probably being silly," the prefect says, glancing at a portrait over your shoulder. "But the castle feels wrong this year. If you're out after dinner, meet me by the Grand Staircase. I want to show you something."

- **1.** Meet the prefect after dinner.
- **2.** Follow her patrol route (she shows them a corridor where the portraits have gone quiet).
- **3.** Find what she was afraid of (the covered painting, Day 1 or 2 at Curfew).

Reward: 30 XP and 10 house points.

TIP

The prefect is drained on Day 2. If the players never met her, the cliffhanger hurts less. Push this quest hard on Day 1.

Stolen Ingredients

When: Day 1, Free time. Professor Grimsby.

READ ALOUD

"Somebody," Grimsby hisses, "has been in my store cupboard. Boomslang skin. Lacewing flies. Gone. If I find out it was a first-year, they will be scrubbing cauldrons until they are forty."

- **1.** Search the Dungeons for clues (sticky fingerprints, a dropped jar).
- **2.** Catch the thief (it is Peeves, hoarding them to throw at students).
- **3.** Return the jars to Grimsby.

Reward: 30 XP, 10 Galleons and two Pepperup Potions each.

TIP

Place **Stolen ingredient jars** as an item somewhere Peeves haunts, like the Grand Staircase. Grimsby being grateful is a seed for clearing him later.

Dueling Club Champion

When: Day 2, Free time. Professor Flitwick.

READ ALOUD

"Dueling Club!" squeaks Professor Flitwick, standing on a pile of books. "Every evening in the Great Hall. Fair fights, friendly spells, nobody gets stunned into next week. Well. Rarely."

- **1.** Beat a Dueling Club rival (place a **Dueling Club rival** and fight).
- **2.** Beat two more rivals.
- **3.** Win the final against an older student (Cassius Thorne, using rival stats).

Reward: 40 XP and 15 house points each.

Wake the Sleepers

When: Day 3, Lunch, after the second victim. Professor Longbottom.

READ ALOUD

"There's a draught," Longbottom says quietly, turning a Mandrake leaf in his fingers. "A Restorative Draught. Old magic. It might bring them back. I'd need Mandrake, and someone with a steady hand at a cauldron."

- **1.** Gather 3 Mandrake leaves (Herbology gives one each; chests and Longbottom can give more).
- **2.** Brew the Restorative Draught (an INT check, or spin Potion brewing).

- **3.** Bring it to the Hospital Wing.

Reward: 60 XP, 20 house points and a Wiggenweld Potion each.

> **TIP**
>
> When they deliver it, give them a **Restorative Draught** moment: the prefect wakes and whispers one clue: "The man in the painting… he was wearing Ashgrove's face."

Where is Bramble?

When: Day 3, Care of Magical Creatures. Professor Scamander, for the Thornbury.

> **READ ALOUD**
>
> *"A hippogriff has been seen at the edge of the forest," Scamander says. "Grey. Proud. Torn tag on her leg." She looks right at the Thornbury. "I believe she might be yours."*

- **1.** Find Bramble's tracks in the Forbidden Forest (spin the forest wheel each visit).
- **2.** Calm Bramble without hurting her (Thornbury has advantage; Creature treats help).
- **3.** Bring her safely out of the forest.

Reward: 50 XP, 15 Galleons and Creature treats each.

> **TIP**
>
> Bramble can return in the finale and carry someone to safety.

The Other Half

When: Day 4, Lunch, when Cassius is seen with a map. For the Fenwick.

> **READ ALOUD**
>
> *Cassius is lounging on the courtyard wall, unfolding a piece of old parchment. It is torn straight down the middle, and the torn edge is exactly the same shape as the one in your pocket.*

- **1.** Find out who has the other half (Cassius).
- **2.** Win it back, by trade, trick or duel.
- **3.** Join the halves.

Reward: 50 XP and a rare Chocolate Frog card.

> **TIP**
>
> When they win it, give the Fenwick **The other half of the Marauder's Map** with Give item. Holding both halves, the map shows the whole castle, and the way down to the Undercroft from the Dungeons.

Card Collector

When: Any free block. A Ravenclaw collector in the library.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *An older Ravenclaw with ink-stained fingers is sorting Chocolate Frog cards into piles. "I'm missing one," she sighs. "A rare. Find it for me and I'll tell you something about the painting nobody else knows."*

- **1.** Find a rare Chocolate Frog card (in an ancient chest, or from The Other Half).
- **2.** Trade it to the collector.

Reward: 25 XP and Felix Felicis.

> TIP
>
> Her secret: "It came with the new portraits. Ashgrove signed for it himself."

Secret quests

Only you can see these until you reveal them. Each one is found by curiosity, not given by a teacher.

The Old Cup

When: Detention in the Trophy Room starts it automatically.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *Polishing the oldest cup in the case, you notice tiny letters engraved beneath the names of a forgotten team: "Where the stars are closest, the second ring waits."*

- **1.** Read the engraving on the old cup.
- **2.** Follow it to the Astronomy Tower.
- **3.** Find what was hidden there (a ring clue and Felix Felicis).

Reward: 30 XP, the second ring clue and Felix Felicis.

The Turning Lock

When: Reveal it when they find the Room of Requirement (walk past the wall three times, thinking of what they need).

> READ ALOUD
>
> *The Room of Requirement opens into a cathedral of forgotten things. Deep inside, on a stone plinth, sits a small iron chest with three stone rings for a lock. From inside comes a faint, steady ticking.*

- **1.** Find the Room of Requirement.
- **2.** Find the three ring clues (Trophy Room, Astronomy Tower, Owlery).
- **3.** Turn the rings to open the lock (the Turning Lock puzzle).

Reward: 60 XP. By hand: the Time-Turner (one use).

TIP

Place the three ring clue items: **Scratched note** in the Trophy Room, **Star chart** on the Astronomy Tower, **Feathered card** in the Owlery.

The Trials Beneath

When: Reveal it when they reach the serpent door below the Dungeons.

READ ALOUD

At the bottom of the forgotten stair stands a door carved with a great stone serpent. Beneath it, cut into the floor, are four words: Brave. Clever. Patient. Wise. The door does not open. Somewhere behind it, something is humming.

- **1.** Get past the Devil's Snare (fight it, or Lumos or Incendio).
- **2.** Light every torch on the Torch Wall.
- **3.** Win the Living Chessboard.
- **4.** Drink from the right bottle (the Seven Bottles).

Reward: 120 XP and 40 house points each.

TIP

There is a second way in: the Marlowe key turned while speaking Parseltongue opens the serpent door directly. Reward either path.

The Painter's Bargain

When: Reveal it to one student who goes near the covered painting alone, ideally Day 5 or 6.

READ ALOUD

In the dark, the painting speaks. Its voice is soft, warm, patient. "You want to protect them. Your friends. I know a curse that cannot be blocked, child. One word, and nothing will ever hurt them again. Prove you deserve it, and it is yours."

- **1.** Find all three pages of Vale's diary (Restricted Section, Black Lake, Shrieking Shack).
- **2.** Decode the diary's runes (the Vale's Diary puzzle).
- **3.** Go to the painting alone, during curfew.
- **4.** Answer the painting's question truthfully.
- **5.** Choose: accept the bargain, or walk away.

Reward: 50 XP. By hand: the Killing Curse.

TIP

Place three **Page of Vale's diary** items. The decoded line tells them to come alone. The painting asks: "What would you give up to never lose again?" Any honest answer is accepted. If they accept, teach the curse from Players tab, **Edit stats and limits**. Nothing is shown on the TV. The price: once a day, Vale can look through that student's eyes. Tell them privately.

PART 5

Puzzles

On the TV, solved out loud, operated by you.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Puzzles tab: press **Put it on the TV**. Phones show "Puzzle on the TV!". The players tell you what to do and you make the moves. Most puzzles detect when they are solved. The solution hides behind **Show the solution (GM only)**. **Close** returns the TV to the map.

TIP

Read the intro on the TV aloud, then step back. Let them argue. Count to sixty before offering the gentle hint. A puzzle solved together is worth +10 house points to each student who helped.

The Living Chessboard

Where and when: The Trials Beneath, third chamber.

READ ALOUD

You step into a vast dark chamber. Torches flare along the walls, and you see you are standing on a giant chessboard. The black pieces tower over you, carved from stone, with blank faces. A voice echoes: "Take your places. White to move. Checkmate in two."

How it plays: Assign each player a white piece (tap a piece, choose their name). They decide moves together. Tap a piece, then its square.

Hint	Say this if they are stuck
Gentle	"The rook is strong, but something is in its way."
Stronger	"What if the bishop moved somewhere it guards the king's only escape?"
Almost the answer	"The bishop wants to go to e6."

Answer: 1. Bishop d7 to e6 (it clears the rook's path and guards g8). Whatever Black does, 2. Rook a7 to h7 is checkmate.

If they fail: Any other first move lets Black escape. A black piece slams down nearby: the student whose piece moved takes d6 damage (adjust HP). Press Reset and try again.

The Torch Wall

Where and when: The Trials Beneath, second chamber. Or anywhere dark.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *A wall of twenty-five iron torches, five by five, most of them cold. When you touch one, it flares or dies, and so do the torches directly around it.*

How it plays: They call a torch by row and column; tap it. It flips along with its neighbours above, below, left and right.

Hint	Say this if they are stuck
Gentle	"Work row by row. Fix the top row, then never touch it again."
Stronger	"To light a dark torch in one row, touch the torch directly below it."
Almost the answer	Name two of the solution torches from the GM panel.

Answer: Six touches: row 1 col 1, row 1 col 2, row 1 col 5, row 3 col 3, row 4 col 1, row 4 col 5. Any order. Other solutions also work.

If they fail: There is no failure, only time. If the clock matters, spin Hogwarts surprises while they work.

The Seven Bottles

Where and when: The Trials Beneath, final chamber.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *Purple flames leap up behind you. Black flames rise ahead. On a table stand seven bottles in a row, and a scroll of clues. One bottle lets you walk through the black fire. One takes you safely back. Two will put you to sleep. Three are poison.*

How it plays: Clues are on the TV. When a student drinks, tap that bottle to reveal it.

Hint	Say this if they are stuck
Gentle	"The tall bottles. What does clue three tell you?"
Stronger	"If the poisons can't sit side by side, where can they go?"
Almost the answer	"The way back is the tiny one at the end."

Answer: Bottle 4, the small gold one. Poisons 1, 3, 5. Sleep 2, 6. The way back is 7.

If they fail: Poison: d6 damage and spin Potion brewing for drama. Sleep: they are out until another student wakes them. Only one student can go forward. That splits the party, which is the point.

The Turning Lock

Where and when: The Room of Requirement, after The Turning Lock quest.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *Three stone rings, each carved with six symbols, turn under your fingers with a grinding sound. Above them, a small arrow. Inside the chest, something ticks.*

How it plays: They name a ring and a direction; turn it. It opens when the right three symbols sit under the arrow.

Hint	Say this if they are stuck
Gentle	"Read your three clue notes again, in order."
Stronger	"What sleeps beneath the castle? What is the lamp of the night?"
Almost the answer	"Serpent, then moon. And who carries every letter?"

Answer: Serpent, Moon, Owl.

If they fail: No failure. The ticking just gets louder.

The Torn Edge

Where and when: Any time the Fenwick studies their half of the map (Day 1 onwards).

> READ ALOUD
>
> *Along the torn edge of the parchment, someone scratched a line of tiny runes in faded ink. The map itself stays stubbornly blank. Perhaps it is waiting to hear something.*

How it plays: They guess letters; reveal a letter when they get it right. O and A start revealed. Nine words.

Hint	Say this if they are stuck
Gentle	"The first word is a single letter. Which letter can be a whole word?"
Stronger	"The last four words are UP __ NO ____. What are troublemakers always up to?"
Almost the answer	Reveal the letters for GOOD.

Answer: I SOLEMNLY SWEAR THAT I AM UP TO NO GOOD.

If they fail: No failure. Once solved, whoever holds the map can open it by saying the words to their phone.

Vale's Diary

Where and when: After they collect all three diary pages (The Painter's Bargain).

> READ ALOUD
>
> *Three pages, stitched together, covered in a spiky script of runes. The ink still smells of paint. Some runes appear again and again.*

How it plays: They guess letters; reveal a letter when they get it right. E and T start revealed.

Hint	Say this if they are stuck
Gentle	"Look at the short words. Which three-letter word appears more than once?"
Stronger	"The word after ONLY is THE. What is the word before WHO?"
Almost the answer	Reveal the letters for ALONE.

Answer: ONLY THE ONE WHO STANDS ALONE MAY LEARN THE CURSE THAT CANNOT BE BLOCKED.

If they fail: No failure. The answer tells them the painting must be visited alone.

The Serpent in the Stars

Where and when: The Astronomy Tower, after The Old Cup or at night.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *The night sky is impossibly clear. Silver numbers shimmer beside eight stars. Carved on the parapet: "Draw the serpent. Begin at its eye, the brightest star, and always move to the next brightest."*

How it plays: They call two stars to join; tap one, then the other.

Hint	Say this if they are stuck
Gentle	"Which is the very brightest? That is the eye."
Stronger	"Compare the sizes. Each line goes to the next biggest star."
Almost the answer	"Start 5, 2, 7…"

Answer: 5, 2, 7, 1, 8, 3, 6, 4.

If they fail: No failure. Wrong lines can be tapped again to remove them.

The Moving Staircases

Where and when: The Grand Staircase, at Curfew, or as a shortcut to the Undercroft.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *The staircases have swung loose and hang at odd angles over the drop. Somewhere below, a door glows. If you can line them up, there is a path.*

How it plays: They name a piece; tap it to turn it a quarter clockwise. The path glows when it connects.

Hint	Say this if they are stuck
Gentle	“Start from the arrow and trace one step at a time.”
Stronger	“The path snakes: right, down twice, right, up, right, then down twice to the door.”
Almost the answer	Read out the first three turns from the GM panel.

Answer: See the GM panel for exact turns. Any working route counts.

If they fail: A wrong turn costs time. If Filch is about, spin Out after curfew.

The Scrambled Portrait

Where and when: Any portrait corridor. The portrait tells them a secret when whole.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *A portrait has been sliced into nine squares and shuffled in its frame. One square is missing. The pieces groan as they slide.*

How it plays: They name a piece next to the gap; tap it to slide it in.

Hint	Say this if they are stuck
Gentle	“Fix the top row first, then the left column.”
Stronger	“Leave the last two rows until the end; rotate them like a wheel.”
Almost the answer	Make the next three moves for them.

Answer: Pieces 1 to 8 in order, gap last. The shortest solution is 16 slides.

If they fail: No failure. When it is whole, the portrait says: “He did not arrive on the train. He was brought.”

The Rune Floor

Where and when: The Trials Beneath, or the Undercroft approach.

> READ ALOUD
>
> *The floor is made of stone tiles, each carved with a rune. Above the far door, five runes are cut deep into the stone. The air smells of old blood.*

How it plays: They say which tile the walker steps on; tap it. A wrong step flashes red and sends them back to the start.

Hint	Say this if they are stuck
Gentle	“The five runes above the door are the only safe ones, in that order.”
Stronger	“You can only step up, left or right. Never diagonally, never back.”
Almost the answer	“Start on the bottom row, fourth tile.”

Answer: Bottom row 4th tile, then (row from the bottom, column): 2-4, 2-5, 3-5, 3-4, 3-3, 4-3, 4-2, 4-1, 5-1, 5-2, 6-2.

If they fail: A wrong step: the floor bites for d4 damage (adjust HP). The walker goes back to the start.

PART 6

The Finale

The seventh night. Below the castle, a painter is waiting to finish himself.

Getting in

There are two ways into the Undercroft. Both are fine. The best finales use both, with the party split.

- **The Trials Beneath:** Devil's Snare, the Torch Wall, the Living Chessboard, the Seven Bottles. Only one student can drink the way forward.
- **The serpent door:** the Marlowe turns the serpent key and speaks Parseltongue. It opens straight into the Undercroft. Spin **They heard you hiss** if anyone is watching.

READ ALOUD

The serpent carved on the door uncoils. Its stone scales grind against each other, and the door swings inward on a breath of cold, painted air. Beyond it, a staircase spirals down into green light.

Setting the stage

ON THE GM SCREEN

Move everyone who gets through to **The Undercroft**. Place: **Ashgrove (possessed)**, two **Paint Wraiths**, and the hazards **Ritual circle**, **Vale's empty canvas**, **Shelf of paint jars**, **Cracked mirror** and **Cold braziers**. Also place **The covered painting** (People), now uncovered.

READ ALOUD

The Undercroft is a vast round chamber of serpent-carved pillars. In the centre, a circle of runes has been painted on the floor in something dark. Inside it stands an empty picture frame, taller than a man, its canvas blank and wet.

Around the circle, in a ring, stand the drained students: grey, silent, upright, staring at nothing. A thin silver light flows from each of them into the empty canvas.

And in front of the frame, his back to you, is Professor Ashgrove. He turns. His eyes are brushstrokes. His smile is not his own. "Ah," says a voice that is not Ashgrove's. "The audience has arrived."

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

"The TV shows everything in the room. What do you do?" This is the moment to let them plan. Count the hazards with them if they miss them.

Phase 1: Ashgrove

ON THE GM SCREEN

Press **Start fight**. Run it as normal. Paint Wraiths take extra punishment from fire: Incendio, or the paint jars (which destroy every wraith at once).

READ ALOUD

"You were my favourite students," Ashgrove says, with tears in his painted eyes. "I am so sorry. He is so very strong." Then his wand rises, and the voice behind his voice laughs.

TIP

Ashgrove is a victim. If anyone tries to talk to the real Ashgrove (CHA 16), give his next attack disadvantage, or let him whisper the canvas is the key.

READ ALOUD

Ashgrove falls to his knees. The paint drains from his eyes in grey tears, and he collapses, himself again, unconscious. For a heartbeat, the chamber is silent. Then the blank canvas ripples, and a man steps out of it.

Phase 2: Corvin Vale

ON THE GM SCREEN

Press **End and share XP** (Ashgrove's XP is shared). Place **Corvin Vale** beside the frame, then press **Start fight** again. Paint Wraiths still standing join the new fight.

READ ALOUD

He is beautiful in the way a painting is beautiful: too perfect, too still, colours too bright. Velvet the colour of old blood. Hands stained with three centuries of paint.

"Corvin Vale," he says, bowing. "Painter. I have waited three hundred years for an audience worth finishing in front of. When the last of their light is in my canvas, I will be real again, and I will never, ever end."

- **Breaking the ritual circle** drops his Defence by 3. Without it, he is very hard to hit.
- **Burning or slashing the canvas** deals 15 to him. Each hit on the canvas makes the drained students flicker with colour.
- **The cracked mirror** reflects a spell for 8. **The braziers** heal the party for 5.
- The **Killing Curse** hits him for 20 if it lands, and the secret wheel spins. Even here, someone might see.

TIP

Vale talks during the fight. Use the players' secrets against them: he knows the Blackwood debt, the Marlowe ancestor, the Quill who saw his eye. A villain who knows your name is far scarier than one with more HP.

Victory

READ ALOUD

Vale reaches for the canvas, and it tears in his hands. Colour floods out of it like a breaking dam: silver, gold, every shade of every student he took. It pours back into the grey figures around the circle, and one by one they gasp and fall, alive, crying, themselves.

Vale looks down at his hands. They are fading. "Unfinished," he whispers, almost in wonder. Then there is only an empty frame, and the smell of turpentine, and somewhere far above, the bell for morning.

ON THE GM SCREEN

Complete **The Hollow Heir** and **The Trials Beneath** on the Quests tab. Give out house points for bravery. Then go to "Ending the night".

Defeat

If the last block of Day 7 ends and Vale still stands, or the whole party is knocked out:

READ ALOUD

The canvas drinks the last of the light. Corvin Vale breathes in, deeply, for the first time in three hundred years, and steps out of the circle on real feet. He walks past you as if you are already a painting. Somewhere above, the portraits begin, very softly, to applaud.

Record a **loss**. It stings, and that is fine. The players can still win the House Cup, and the awards still happen.

PART 7

Ending the Night

The last fifteen minutes are what they will talk about tomorrow.

Tonight's awards

ON THE GM SCREEN

TV shows tab: **Tonight's awards**. The TV fills with awards worked out from the whole night: Heaviest Hitter, Unbreakable, Point Machine, Luckiest Wand, Glorious Disaster, Top of the Class, Treasure Hunter, Wand Never Rests.

TIP

Read each one out like an award ceremony. Ask the winner for a one-line speech.

The House Cup

ON THE GM SCREEN

TV shows tab: **House Cup ceremony**. The winning house takes over the TV with the standings, and the House Cup goes into each winner's trophy cabinet on their account.

READ ALOUD

The Great Hall is hung with banners in the winning colours. The Headmaster raises his glass. "A strange year. A frightening one. And at the end of it, students who would not stand by. The House Cup goes to…"

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

Pause. Long. Then read the house name. Then let them cheer.

Record the result and save the characters

ON THE GM SCREEN

On the DM dashboard, press **Record win** or **Record loss**. A win puts the campaign trophy, Saviour of Hogwarts, in every player's cabinet. Either way, **every character is saved to its player's profile**: level, XP, house, stats, spells, wand, robes, familiar, bag and Galleons. There is also a **Save characters now** button on the Players tab if you want to save at the end of a session.

Players see their character on their dashboard under **Your characters**, marked "Year 1 complete". In Year 2, the family picker offers **Continue as…** and everything comes back. New players joining in Year 2 start at level 5.

The epilogue and the Year 2 hook

READ ALOUD

The train pulls out of Hogsmeade station under a bright summer sky. Behind you, the castle grows small. In the last carriage, between the luggage racks, there is nothing at all, just an empty space on the wall where something used to hang. You are fairly sure it is gone. Fairly sure.

Then, after a pause, read the sting. This is what Year 2 grows from.

READ ALOUD

That night, long after the last student has gone home, the Headmaster's office is dark and quiet. Around the walls, the portraits of every headmaster who ever served Hogwarts are asleep in their frames.

All except one. The frame belongs to a headmaster from three hundred years ago, the one who first welcomed a young painter named Corvin Vale to the castle. The frame is empty.

On the desk below it lies a single sheet of paper, in handwriting nobody living would recognise. It says: One down. Six to go.

WAIT FOR THE PLAYERS

Say nothing. Let them react. Then: "See you in Year 2."

TIP

The empty headmaster's frame, "six to go" (one for each year left), and the fact that Vale was invited: that is enough to build Year 2 on, without promising anything yet.

APPENDIX

Quick Reference

Voices, entrances, clues, and what changed.

NPC voices

Character	Voice and manner	Wants
Professor Ashgrove	Warm, encouraging, remembers names. Too warm.	To be loved. Now: to be free of Vale.
Professor Grimsby	Clipped, sarcastic, never looks up. Secretly kind.	To wake the victims without anyone noticing.
Professor Flitwick	Squeaky, excitable, stands on books.	A champion for the Dueling Club.
Professor Longbottom	Gentle, nervous laugh, talks to plants.	To save the students. Believes in the Restorative Draught.
Professor Scamander	Dreamy, distracted, the suitcase thumps.	Creatures treated kindly. Bramble home.
Professor Vance	Crisp and exact. Taps her wand on the desk.	Precision. Order. Silence.
Madam Hooch	Barks like a sports coach. Hates excuses.	Nobody falling off a broom.
Argus Filch	Mutters, shuffles, threatens. Talks to his cat.	To catch someone, anyone, after curfew.
Peeves	Shrieks, rhymes, throws things.	Chaos. He stole Grimsby's ingredients.
Prefect Sinclair	Brisk, tired, protective of her sibling.	For someone to believe her.
Cassius Thorne	Lazy, smug drawl, flips a Galleon.	To win. Holds the other map half.
Corvin Vale	Velvet-soft, patient, speaks in colours and brushstrokes.	To finish his self-portrait and live forever.

Common room entrances

House	Where	How to get in
Gryffindor	Tower, off the Grand Staircase	Tell the Fat Lady the password: "Lionheart".
Ravenclaw	Tower, off the Grand Staircase	Answer the eagle knocker: "The more you share me, the more of me there is. What am I?" (Knowledge.) A wrong answer means waiting for someone cleverer.
Hufflepuff	Basement, through the Kitchens	Tap the barrel two from the bottom, middle of the second row, in the rhythm of "Helga Hufflepuff". Wrong barrel: a shower of vinegar.
Slytherin	Dungeons, under the lake	Say the password to the bare stone wall: "Silver Tongue".

The Kitchens are behind a painting of a fruit bowl. Tickle the pear and it giggles and turns into a door handle.

Clues: where they are found

Clue	Found	Pin under
Grimsby's store cupboard was raided	Day 1, Grimsby's rant	Grimsby
Every portrait near an attack had gone silent	Day 2, the first victim	The covered painting
Ashgrove's classroom has more paintings every day	Day 4, any visit to Defence	Ashgrove
Filch has keys to every corridor	Day 4, asking Filch or detention	Filch
Cassius was seen with half of an old map	Day 4, the courtyard	Cassius
A page about Corvin Vale	Day 4, Restricted Section (before Free time)	The covered painting
The covered painting hangs in a different corridor each night	Any night, asking a ghost or portrait	The covered painting
The covered painting's eyes follow a Quill	Whenever the Quill tells the others	The covered painting
Grimsby was found standing over the third victim	Day 5, Curfew	Grimsby
Grimsby was secretly brewing a draught (clears)	Day 5 onward, his office or the bottle	Grimsby
Filch was supervising a detention on night two (clears)	Detention, or asking around	Filch
Cassius was in the Hospital Wing on night three (clears)	Visiting the Hospital Wing	Cassius
A ghost saw a figure "step out of a frame"	Day 6, the Three Broomsticks or any ghost	A Hogwarts ghost
Ashgrove's eyes looked like brushstrokes	Day 6, Free time	Ashgrove
Flecks of wet paint on Ashgrove's sleeve	Day 6, looking closely	Ashgrove

TIP

Pin a clue under the wrong suspect if that is what the players believe. The board shows their theory, not the truth.

Items to place before each day

Item	Where	For
Stolen ingredient jars	Grand Staircase (Peeves)	Stolen Ingredients
Torn page about Corvin Vale	Restricted Section, Day 4	The main mystery
Scratched note (first ring)	Trophy Room	The Turning Lock
Star chart (second ring)	Astronomy Tower (or from The Old Cup)	The Turning Lock
Feathered card (last ring)	Owlery	The Turning Lock
Page of Vale's diary (×3)	Restricted Section, Black Lake, Shrieking Shack	The Painter's Bargain
Rare Chocolate Frog card	An ancient chest anywhere	Card Collector

Media files

Everything below is optional: the app has a built-in fallback for every file. Put files in the project's **public** folder with exactly these names, then check them on the GM screen's **Media** tab, which ticks every file it finds and lets you preview the cutscenes, sounds and music.

What	File	Notes
Intro video	video/intro.mp4	1920×1080 MP4 (H.264, AAC). Replaces the ident and title. Any length; the book opens when it ends. The current pair runs about 16 seconds.
Jump scare video	video/jumpscare.mp4	1920×1080 MP4. Plays for mimics instead of the drawn maw. Keep it short (2 to 4 seconds).
Intro music	sounds/music/intro.mp3	Plays under the opening cutscene.
Music tracks	sounds/music/<id>.mp3	castle, great-hall, diagon, mystery, forest, battle, undercroft, victory. Royalty-free or Creative Commons only.
Narration	sounds/narration/page-1.mp3 to page-6.mp3	Your voice reading each storybook page. Plays as the page turns.
Storybook pictures	story/page-1.jpg to page-6.jpg	1200×1500 (4:5 portrait). The left-hand page of the book.
Portraits	portraits/<family>.jpg	blackwood, sinclair, fenwick, thornbury, quill, marlowe. Square, face centred (cropped to a circle).
Maps	maps/<place id>.jpg	All 35 places; ids are in public/maps/README.md. Wide 16:9, high overhead view.
Puzzle portrait	puzzles/portrait.jpg	Square. Cut into the 3×3 Scrambled Portrait.
People	art/people/<id>.png	Everyone the players can meet. Square, face centred (shown in a circle on the map).
Monsters	art/monsters/<id>.png	Everything they can fight. Square, creature centred.
Mimics	art/mimics/hungry-trunk.png, painted-double.png	What they look like after they spring.
Items	art/items/<id>.png	Pick-ups, shop goods, and items/wand.png for every wand. Shown on the map, in the bag and in the shops.
Chests and hazards	art/chests/<id>.png, art/hazards/<id>.png	Square, object centred.

Every picture has a ready-made prompt for an image tool in **docs/art/art-prompts.md**, with its exact file name. Pictures replace the emoji wherever that thing appears; anything without one keeps its emoji.

Testing on your own

You can play a student yourself to try anything before game night, using a test student on your own account.

- **Add it:** start a practice game, go to the **Players** tab, open **Test student**, pick a family and press **Add a test student**. It appears where the party is, already sorted and with its vault open.
- **Play it:** press **player screen** to open the phone view in a new tab, or open the game on your phone signed in as you. Keep the GM screen open too: it is what carries out everything the student does.
- **Kits:** one tap each for top level, every spell (locked dark spells too), one of every item (both halves of the Marauder's Map too), lots of mana, a full refill, Galleons, and resetting the once-a-day things (the family ability, the map, a duel reaction).
- **Good things to try:** the Marauder's Map by voice, a reaction duel against Corvin Vale, dark spells and status effects, a class mini-game, a chest, the shop.

- **Two-player things** (Protego saves, the Painted Double, votes) need a second account: sign in with another Google account in a private window or on a second phone and join with the code.
- **Before game night:** press **Remove the test student**, or just start a fresh game. A test student is never saved to a profile and never gets a trophy.

Printing this book

- **Page size:** A4 portrait (210 × 297 mm).
- **Your cover:** save it as *docs/dm-guide/cover.jpg* (or .png) and rebuild. It fills page 1 edge to edge and a title page follows. Design it at 2480 × 3508 pixels (A4 at 300 dpi). If the printer wants bleed, make it 2551 × 3579 pixels (3 mm extra on every side) and keep text 10 mm away from the edges.
- **Binding:** spiral or wire binding lets the book lie flat beside the laptop. Print double-sided.
- **Colour:** the read-aloud boxes are parchment-coloured and the GM boxes teal. Both stay readable in black and white.

Version log

Version	Date	Changes
3.0	October 2026	Test student: play a character on your own account to try everything, with one-tap kits for spells, items, levels and resets.
2.9	October 2026	The Marauder's Map: opened by voice, it shows the castle in ink with everyone's footsteps and every treasure, live on the TV. Once a day, fades after 60 seconds. New puzzle, The Torn Edge, holds the words.
2.8	October 2026	The reaction duel: boss spells come with a countdown on the target's phone. Shield, Dodge or Counter in time, friends can cast Protego, and Vale is faster and can feint in phase 2.
2.7	October 2026	Dark magic: a series spellbook of dark, blood and later-year spells locked by year and level, Corruption from 0 to 10, status effects that count down in fights (Bleed, Stunned, Silenced, Fear and more), and villain spells cast by monsters.
2.6	October 2026	The accusation vote: players vote on their phones for the culprit. Keep it a hunch, or make it the final accusation, which reveals the truth, pays XP and house points, and weakens the bosses if the table is right.
2.5	October 2026	The Painted Double: an Imposter-style party game with your own words and hints, phone voting and a TV reveal.
2.4	October 2026	The Forbidden Forest fight is now a Thornback Boar (Day 3 free time and the forest wheel). Creature treats or a Thornbury can calm it.
2.3	October 2026	Pictures for people, monsters, items, chests and hazards (public/art), replacing the emoji on the map, phones and shops. An image prompt for every picture in docs/art.
2.2	October 2026	The scene counter (2 things at lunch, 3 in free time, 2 at curfew) shown on the TV and phones. Missed quests now arrive by Owl Post, spread through the week. Fixed new mornings not restoring HP.
2.1	October 2026	The living castle: every person has a place for all 35 blocks of the week and moves there on Advance time, along with the clues, chests, hazards and monsters for that block. Quests on offer, conversations on the GM screen, and the companion Conversation Book.
2.0	October 2026	Final edition for Year 1. Written by Zibby. Custom intro and jump scare videos, the Media tab for testing, the media file list, print notes and support for a designed cover.
1.4	October 2026	Owl Post, yearly levels with level-up bonuses, saved characters carrying into Year 2, a pacing plan (three sessions, what to cut), and the Year 2 hook.
1.3	October 2026	Mimics: The Hungry Trunk and The Painted Double, with a jump scare on the TV and phones.

Version	Date	Changes
1.2	October 2026	Spells tab: teach any spell from a library of 25, Patronus forms, custom spells, secret or announced.
1.1	October 2026	Opening cutscene (studio ident, title, storybook with family picking), sound effects, music, and the main event phone lock.
1.0	October 2026	First edition. Matches the app with: families, ceremonies, clock, classes and minigames, map and tokens, fights, wheels, quests and secret quests, nine TV puzzles, suspect board, detention, hazards, awards and the House Cup.

When the app changes, update this book in the same step: edit the content files, bump the version, add a line here, and rebuild.